complex and intricate set of activities that included organizing, gathering, testing, housing and even feeding those waiting to be repatriated.

Starting first at Wuhan and then moving on to Italy and beyond, this involved an intensive engagement with local, provincial and national authorities. And it covered everybody, from tourists and students to professionals and workers, even pilgrims, fishermen and seafarers. It was not limited to Indians coming back. Many staying abroad, in the Gulf, for instance, were given support directly or by interceding with local governments. Here, too, the results of cultivation by political leaders and diplomats paid off.

A more recent example was that of the Indian community caught up in armed civil strife in Sudan in April 2023. Tensions may have been steadily building up over the past year, but nevertheless, expatriates are usually reluctant to leave until the worst case actually happens. In this instance, when it suddenly did, it put almost 4,000 Indian nationals in jeopardy. Overnight, the Indian response mobilized by setting up the command centre at home for what came to be named as Operation Kaveri. At the same time, Indian aircraft were positioned in Saudi Arabia for short-notice flights, while Indian naval vessels were sent to the Red Sea. The extrication process was again incredibly complicated because our nationals were dispersed in small numbers across a vast area. In the civil war situation, law and order broke down completely and even basic necessities became difficult to access. The Indian Embassy worked under the most challenging circumstances, including the occupation of its premises by a warring party. The solution was to evacuate as safely, inconspicuously and rapidly as possible, three objectives that often collided especially in the face of personal and political pressures.

Yet, it was an operation that delivered fully because it was a combination of a committed official presence on the ground, adept diplomacy with neighbours and enablers and a detailed SOP that had been honed over years. Our diplomats and military personnel performed outstandingly, often taking high personal risks. We saw partners like the Saudis, the British and the Egyptians go out of their way to help as well. If there is a common thread among these stressful experiences, it is that of larger dangers that impact individual lives. And that is, in fact, a predicament all through human history.